A Short History of Coastal Lighthouses

Lighthouses have guided sailors along dangerous coastlines for thousands of years, evolving from simple bonfires on hilltops to the automated, solar-powered beacons used today.

The earliest known lighthouse, the Pharos of Alexandria, was built around 280 BC and is believed to have stood over 100 meters tall, making it one of the tallest structures in the ancient world.

The Age of Stone Towers

During the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, engineers such as John Smeaton pioneered the use of interlocking stone blocks to build lighthouses that could survive direct waves crashing over them during storms.

The Eddystone Lighthouse off the coast of Cornwall was rebuilt several times, and Smeaton's 1759 design became the template for wave-swept lighthouse construction for the next century.

Automation and Decline of Keepers

Through the twentieth century, electric lamps, timers, and eventually solar panels with photocells gradually replaced the human lighthouse keepers who had once lived on site to trim wicks and wind clockwork rotation mechanisms by hand.

By the 1990s most lighthouses in wealthy coastal nations had been fully automated, and the keeper became a largely historical profession, with many former keeper's quarters converted into small museums.